
England physicality in a press is unmatched; keep doing this, please

Published by

Dharnish Iqbal

Estimated reading time

4 min

Added on

2026-10-06

Address

<https://www.football365.com/news/england-physicality-press-croatia-tactics>

England physicality in a press is unmatched; keep doing this, please

It's been 83 days since England's painful World Cup semi-final loss to Argentina.

There were some fabulous individual heroics in the knockouts of the tournament, but [the rancour from the sobering defeat to Messi and co.](#) remains.

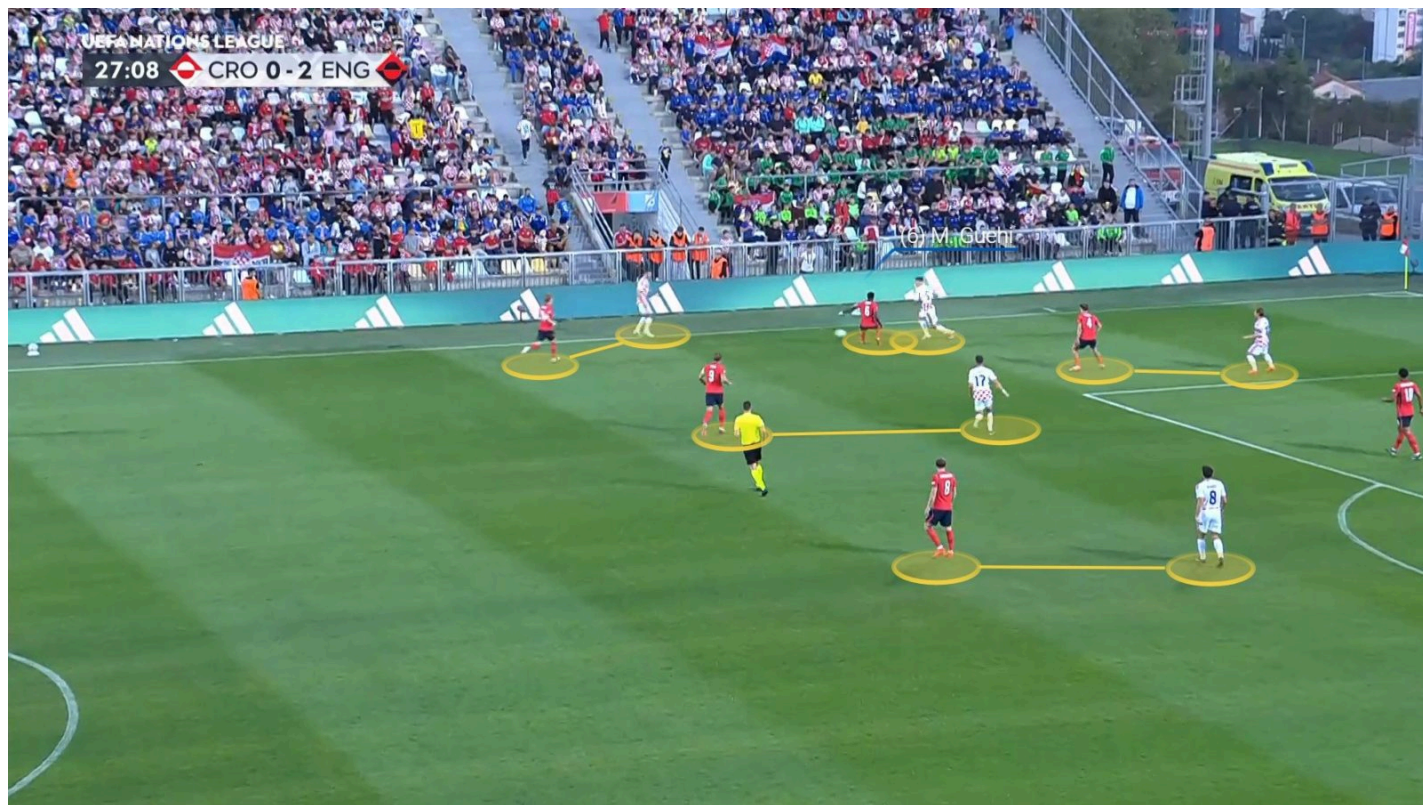
The manner in which England dropped back and invited pressure ignited so much debate, as it was the one time even your aunt who never watches football tuned in to see whether England could make their first final in 60 years.

It's hard not to think of the painful semi-final as we watch England again, but are we seeing something fabulous develop that can lure us in again and be perfected with a Euros on home soil in a couple of years?

If the Croatia result is anything to go by, then the answer is yes. We have to remember, a lot of these players can treat this international break as something of a vacation, but [the intensity, tactics and general panache in the 7-0 win](#) need to be admired and unpacked.

So, what's going on then? What did England exactly do to overwhelm Croatia, and could this be Tuchel's England going forward? Everything is crossed...

England pressed high v Croatia



England pressed high v Croatia.

Yes, that is Marc Guehi and Ezri Konsa pushed up high in the press to pin Croatia in one corner.

It's maybe something we haven't seen since England's first game of the World Cup against the same opponent, but it's encouraging that Tuchel can instruct and coach a press and England can execute it.

It's extremely ballsy to push a centre-back that high in a press, but that is what your centre-back needs to do if you're pressing out of possession.

On the rare occasions Croatia did have it at the back, England didn't let them out with a physical press pushing up the defence.

It was effective because it trapped the Croats in one corner of the pitch and they couldn't get out.

Sure, it's risky, but I would much rather see this than the painful, 'patient' approach the Three Lions took after [they beat Croatia 4-2 in the World Cup opener](#).

Also, against sides like Croatia (sorry, Modric mate), this is the approach England can take because more often than not, they're going to win the ball back to create dangerous situations (like we saw).

There aren't many teams around the world in general who press anymore; the club schedule is too exhausting.

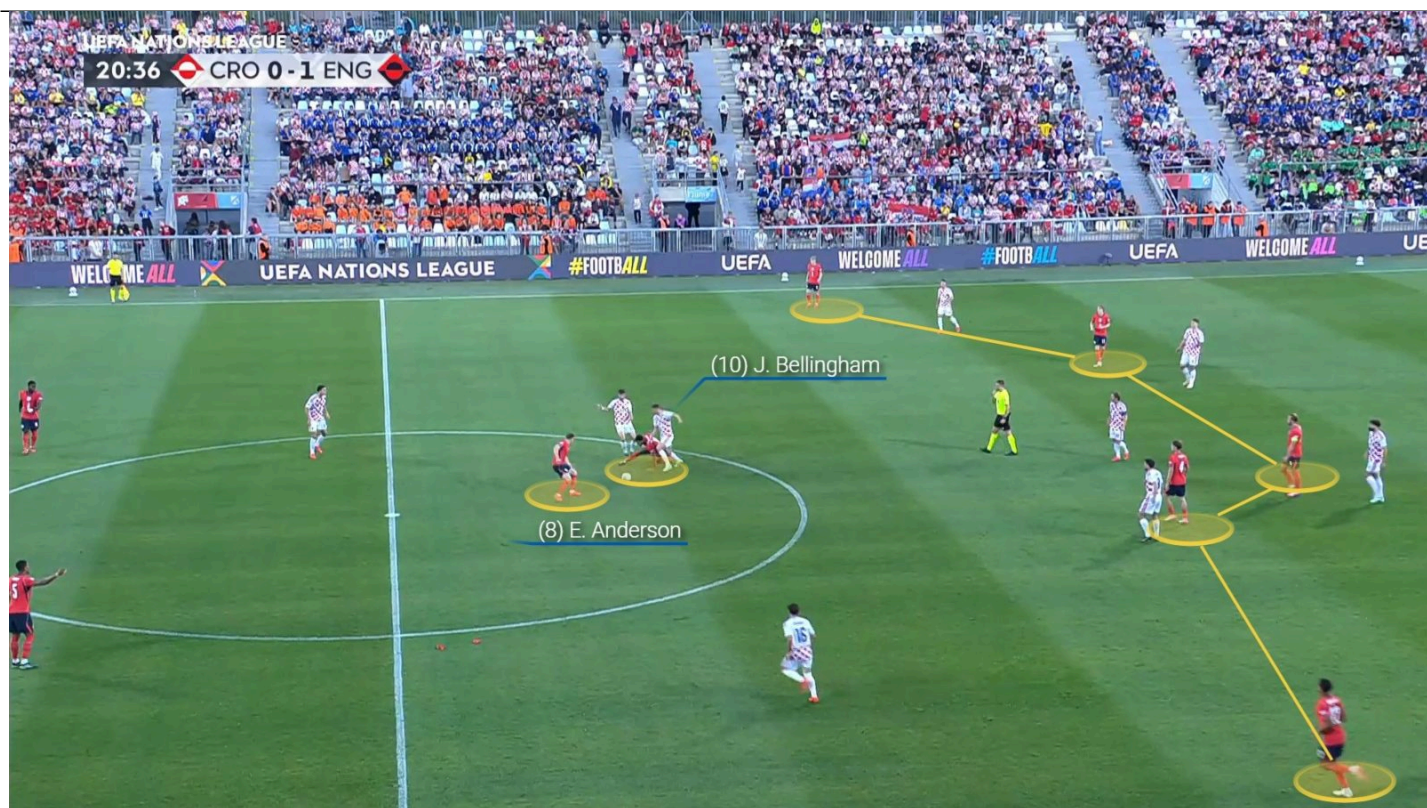
But the slower nature of international football may encourage England to keep adding the spice of pressing, and if the results against Croatia in the Nations League and in the World Cup are anything to go by, it's something Jude Bellingham and co should keep doing.

Their physicality in a press is unmatched.

Kane and Bellingham dropping deep for England

Credit needs to be given to Tuchel for unlocking the monster that is Bellingham.

The former Borussia Dortmund attacker is relentlessly effective because he can do it all but has a fantastic nous for arriving in the box to finish off the move he started. He has the same license he did in his excellent first Madrid season under Carlo Ancelotti to move freely, and he doesn't need a position to be effective.



Jude Bellingham drops deep for England

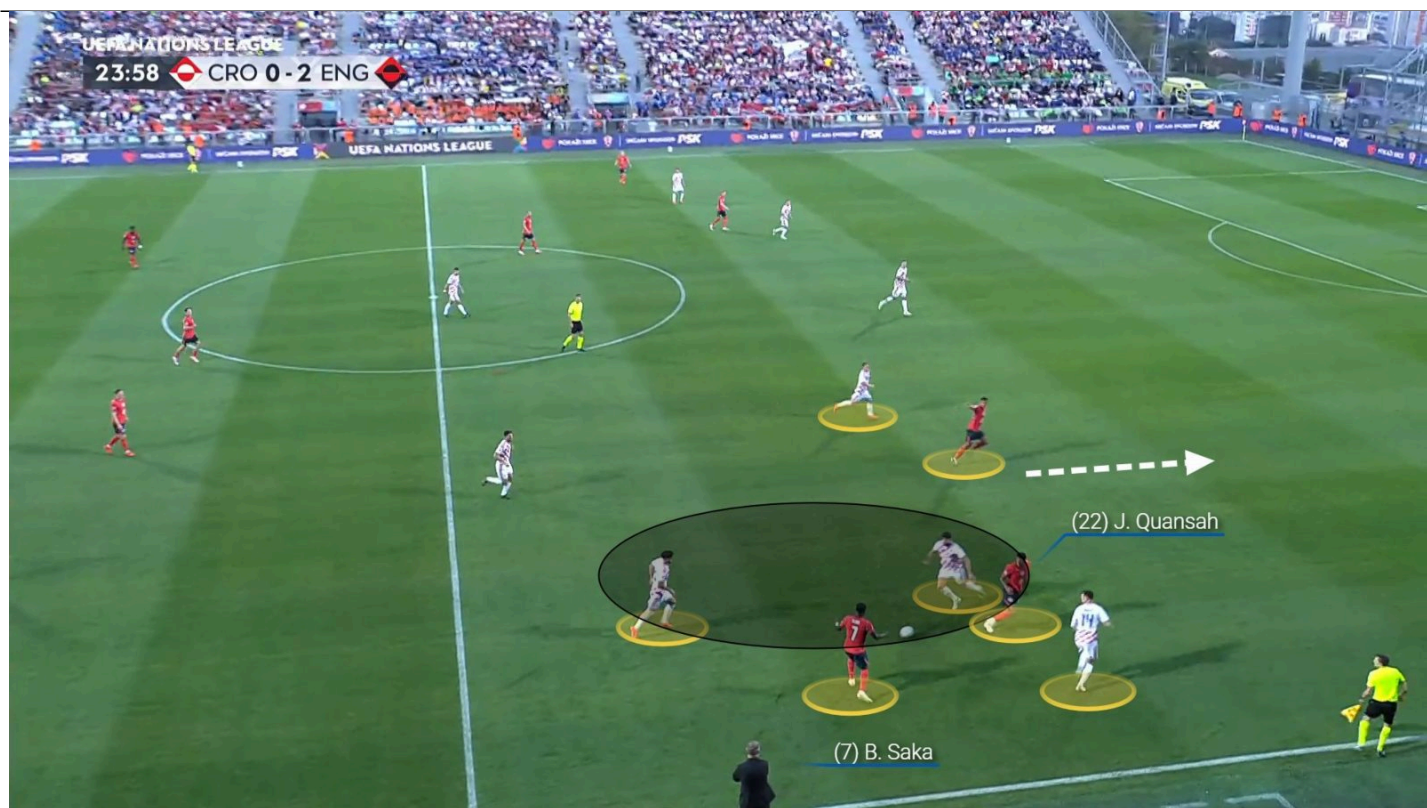
It helps that Harry Kane does the same thing. When you have two attackers who are capable of dropping deep, it takes defenders with them.

After that, what you need is players who occupy the defence in their absence, and England did that with their wingers central and the full-backs wide.

When Declan Rice is in the team, he is more of a deep-lying tempo-setter, but Elliot Anderson can do the same thing and get England moving forward whilst linking up with Kane and Bellingham.

England moved Croatia to one side

England were able to move Croatia's back five around and find gaps in behind because they were able to attract many players to one zone.



England attracted Croatia to one zone (1)

Using a full-back and winger, Ivan Perisic, Josko Gvardiol and Luka Modric were all attracted to the right-hand side. When England used quick interchanges, they occupied so many Croatian players on one side of the pitch and then later on, crossed the ball to the other side.

It was the move of staying wide, luring players into a tackle and then using a runner in behind that really hurt Croatia.

Can England do this again?

Look, we can never really know what happens until a tournament arrives. It's difficult to predict what will happen because there are more factors than just tactics.

It's intense pressure over an extremely small period, but from what I've seen over the international break? I like it a lot.

Even in the loss to Spain, at the very least, England played with thrust and vigour. Tuchel has never been known as an attacking manager. His speciality is being a pragmatist.

But maybe the painful loss to Argentina taught him something. Even if England are to go down and lose, he's realised it's better to do it with a gung-ho attitude.

The emphatic Croatia win and Spain's performance showcase that, and it's an England I can see myself getting behind again.

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.